

Speaker 1 [00:00:03] So first, I'd like to know how you'd like us to refer to your partner—girlfriend, spouse, partner, or something else?

Speaker 2 [00:00:11] By their first name.

Speaker 1 [00:00:13] What's their first name then?

Speaker 2 [00:00:15] [Partner].

Speaker 1 [00:00:16] [Partner], very well. How long have you been with [partner]?

Speaker 2 [00:00:20] I've been with him for [1-5] years, and we've been living together for [1-5] year and a half.

Speaker 1 [00:00:28] I'd like you to tell me first about your love story, the relationship you're currently in with [partner].

Speaker 2 [00:00:35] Do you want my feelings or how we met, or...?

Speaker 1 [00:00:40] All of it at once, indeed, yes.

Speaker 2 [00:00:41] All of it at once. Well. (laughs) I met him in [Year], I was at work. It was at my [occupation], I work in a [store], and I was at the [location], and he was my customer. We met while masked—it was quite strange, as a way to meet, but oh well. After several coincidences, we ran into each other in the street, talked, and became friends—not exactly friends, but good acquaintances. I didn't have his contact, so I didn't see him outside the store unless by chance. One day, he invited me to his birthday. I didn't know his friends or the general atmosphere, so I wasn't very keen. But I told him okay, maybe another time would be better, and I gave him my number. Later, we met for tea, and I realized I really liked him a lot, both physically and in his way of being, his lifestyle. I have a socially "healthy" lifestyle—I eat organic, I don't smoke, I don't drink, I don't particularly party, and so on. He sometimes eats organic. We met in an organic store, so it made sense. He doesn't smoke or drink either. For me, that was a very good point. We got together fairly quickly. Each summer, I go back to my parents', now my mom's. During one summer, we didn't see each other immediately, but we talked a lot through messages. He joined me at my parents' for the rest of the summer, and we got together, and it worked very well between us. We were always at each other's places and started thinking that paying two rents was a bit much. He is a [occupation] and at that time was looking for a studio to make music. He later got into video, so he had a lot of equipment to store. I took the opportunity to suggest that we look for a two-bedroom apartment. We found something smaller, but we found a place with enough space for him to work. So, that's the history of our story. As for how I feel, I think I can summarize it in two words: I feel good, and I think our relationship is a bit magical (laughs), a bit magical.

Speaker 1 [00:03:44] It's a bit magical.

Speaker 2 [00:03:45] Yeah, yeah, yeah. We agree on a lot of things, even though we are two individuals and remain different or disagree on some things. We've never argued. We have our emotions, and it can happen that emotions come out as anger, joy, sadness—human emotions, you know. But we've never fought. We're always talking and sharing a lot of things. We're very close, and I find that so important. I've never experienced that in a relationship before. I think it's great to be able to experience that with someone.

Speaker 1 [00:04:27] To be so close.

Speaker 2 [00:04:29] Yeah, yeah. It's something you can have with certain friendships, or with siblings. But having that in a romantic relationship is really amazing.

Speaker 1 [00:04:39] You think it's something different compared to your previous relationships, for example.

Speaker 2 [00:04:46] Oh, totally. I've never experienced this before. I have a fresh example: before meeting him, I was coming out of a relationship. I ended a relationship for him, in a way. It was a long-distance relationship that lasted [1-5] year and a half. That person was much more focused on appearances and doing things right, had a socially accepted and valued job, was quite good-looking, and from the [Location]. Without generalizing, I noticed that in the [Location], there's more emphasis on appearance than in other regions of [Country]. He and his family and friends were a perfect example. With [partner], I don't feel that focus on appearances. I feel like I can be myself.

Speaker 1 [00:05:49] You are yourself.

Speaker 2 [00:05:50] I am myself. Without filters, without anything. I am myself.

Speaker 1 [00:05:56] Again, something you didn't necessarily find in your previous relationships.

Speaker 2 [00:05:59] No, maybe once or twice, but those relationships didn't last. Another thing I haven't mentioned is that my relationship with [partner] is my longest relationship. That's significant.

Speaker 1 [00:06:15] You've been together for [1-5] years? You told me [1-5] years?

Speaker 2 [00:06:18] Well, it's been [1-5] years now.

Speaker 1 [00:06:20] Alright.

Speaker 2 [00:06:21] And it's not over (laughs).

Speaker 1 [00:06:24] You mentioned in your speech that compared to your previous relationships, there were things that changed, like the closeness and the simplicity in being. I'd

like you to compare the quality of your current relationship with [partner] to your past relationships. What can you say about that?

Speaker 2 [00:06:51] It's complicated because every relationship is different. There are elements of comparison, and at the same time, each relationship is unique. There were things I loved in other relationships that I don't necessarily find with him, or much less. But there are fundamental things for me that I didn't have in other relationships, like this closeness and the ability to be playful. I tend to be very joyful, to always have a zest for life, and to express my joy whenever possible. These are things I could never really do in previous relationships, but now I can do without, I was going to say without limits, well, let's say that when joy is there and emotions are there, they can come out without any judgment. That's very important.

Speaker 1 [00:07:51] So if I understand what you're saying, compared to your previous relationships, related to what you mentioned about appearances, there's no judgment and you have the possibility to be yourself.

Speaker 2 [00:08:05] Yes, and beyond the absence of judgment, I don't feel like in a previous relationship where my integrity was attacked. For example, at a restaurant, if you laugh too loudly, the person might say, "Hey, be careful," or "You embarrassed me, oh my, you embarrassed me." That's something I experienced once, and I never want to experience it again. It makes you feel dirty, like you're not the person's object, but more like an accessory. The person is either proud of you and feels valued with you, or if you make a mistake, you embarrass them. I don't want that anymore.

Speaker 1 [00:08:56] That's what you mean by an attack on your integrity. The fact that...

Speaker 2 [00:09:02] ...You no longer have the right to exist as a human being with accepted and less accepted traits. It's part of us as human beings, with qualities, flaws, emotions, a physical body, an emotional and psychological background, and different experiences from the person opposite us.

Speaker 1 [00:09:32] So, if I understand correctly, there's a strong notion of acceptance of the other person in what you're telling me now.

Speaker 2 [00:09:42] Yes, for me, it's fundamental.

Speaker 1 [00:09:47] Again, something you didn't necessarily have or perhaps not as much in your previous relationships.

Speaker 2 [00:09:52] Yes. There are also things, it's a bit about the big words, certain pillars that I find important and that seem important in my relationships, but also very concrete things like physical closeness, cuddling, kissing—how to show love to the other person and how the other person shows us love. We all have different ways of feeling loved and giving love to others. It can be, uh, I read [Author], it can be spending quality time with the other person, cuddling, saying nice things, things the other wants to hear or that we want to say, "I love you," etc. It can be giving gifts. What seemed very important to me was defining what is important for

me and understanding the other person's language as well. I've been in relationships where people showed their love through gifts or love letters, but that's not me at all. I need to spend quality time with people—it can be a restaurant, a walk, grocery shopping, but spending time where we are fully present with each other. I've been in relationships where these moments always included a phone, and the person was unavailable. In relationships where asking for a hug led to expectations of going to bed, I was like, "No, I just want a hug." These are things you don't necessarily realize at the beginning of a relationship, the other person's language. It's something I tried to learn quickly in previous relationships. I've been in relationships where it worked well despite different languages, and others where it didn't work at all. Now, I'm in a relationship where we share the same language, and that's beautiful.

Speaker 1 [00:12:16] You said at one point that everyone has different ways of loving. I'd like to know...

Speaker 2 [00:12:23] At least we don't express it the same way.

Speaker 1 [00:12:25] Sorry, I didn't hear you.

Speaker 2 [00:12:26] Excuse me, maybe not the same way of loving, but we demonstrate it differently or feel it differently.

Speaker 1 [00:12:39] Maybe to... Yes, go ahead.

Speaker 2 [00:12:40] No, excuse me, I finished my sentence.

Speaker 1 [00:12:43] Go ahead, you were going to say something.

Speaker 2 [00:12:45] Uh, no, I was finishing my sentence.

Speaker 1 [00:12:50] Alright. So, I'd like to know how you know your partner loves you?

Speaker 2 [00:12:53] Well, I know because, well, there are so many reasons. I know because we spend moments without the phone, moments where we watch a stream together and comment on it. We play together, pause the stream and discuss it. We have quality time together outside, being available for each other. We are very close, as I said earlier. We are demonstrative; we're not at opposite ends of the room. When we want to cuddle, we cuddle. Whether we're at home or outside, there's never an issue with cuddling. Some people are hesitant outside, but we're not. We hold hands if we want to. We give each other gifts, although it's more for birthdays and such. We take an interest in each other. We're both creative, with artistic universes that complement each other. He's into audiovisual, music, video, and I'm more into visual arts—painting, sculpture, photography, etc. We have overlapping issues and I feel we understand each other and listen to each other. When one of us experiences strong emotions, like I have, he's always there, and I know he'll be there. Even if he says nothing, he's there, and I know he listens. Likewise, when he has a problem or feels bad, he may not talk about it, but I sense it, and I ask him. If he wants to talk, he does; if not, he doesn't. But he knows I'm there too. We don't step on each other's toes, even though we live together daily. I was worried about

living together, that we'd always be on top of each other, but it's not like that. I do things I'd do if I lived alone. It doesn't stop me from living my life, exercising, studying, working, cooking what I want. I remain an individual, he remains an individual, but we are together.

Speaker 1 [00:16:07] But you're still together.

Speaker 2 [00:16:08] Yes, we're together and not by default.

Speaker 1 [00:16:17] You said earlier, "I feel like we understand each other."

Speaker 2 [00:16:23] Yes. (laughs) Do I need to elaborate?

Speaker 1 [00:16:26] Yes, we're here to get your feelings, your opinions on all these things.

Speaker 2 [00:16:34] Well, again, it's a broad question. There's a lot I could say. Sometimes we say the same things at the same time. It happens very often—facing a situation, we'll say or make the same expression or onomatopoeia or say the same word at the same time. We'll look at each other and burst out laughing. Over time, we learn to understand and anticipate each other's reactions in given situations. In new situations, that's not always the case. I'm often surprised by his ability to respond to certain events or his reactions to things. Sometimes I have a preconceived idea, but I don't know how he'll react, and when I see his reaction, it might surprise me, but never in a bad way. He recently quit a [group] he was part of, and I was disappointed because I liked the group and felt emotionally involved. But it doesn't stop me from loving him and supporting him. When he comes back from rehearsals, I see he's sad, tired, and angry, and quitting the group relieves him. I know it's for projects that suit him better, and seeing him happy is so important to me.

Speaker 1 [00:18:19] Yes, it's important.

Speaker 2 [00:18:21] Yes, very important.

Speaker 1 [00:18:27] You mentioned earlier in the interview your current relationship compared to your past relationships. If you were to compare the quality of your current relationship with those of your friends, what would you say?

Speaker 2 [00:18:42] Well, I don't have many close friends, so it's complicated to talk about. The first difference is that I don't live with my close friends daily, so I don't know the details of their lifestyle. I prefer seeing my friends at specific times for an evening or an event, to spend quality time with them. But I might not have the same fun with them or want to do the same things. We bring different things to each other. We can give advice when someone has a problem. I have friends who do bodybuilding, like me, and we can share tips and jokes about it. My boyfriend doesn't do bodybuilding, so we can't share those jokes. But it complements... well, it adds something different in other areas that are mine, and just socializing in a different way. We have mutual friends and separate circles of friends. He knows my friends at least by name or has met them, but they're not his friends, they're mine. And my friends know him by name or have seen him. Also, with my friends, I don't cuddle or kiss them, and I'm not physically

attracted to them. Even if I find some male friends attractive, I don't want a relationship with them. That's the main difference.

Speaker 1 [00:20:24] You mentioned several times in your speech "quality time," "it's quality time."

Speaker 2 [00:20:32] Yes, very important to me. I see my overall life like that, beyond the couple. I want to spend moments in my life, wherever I am, whatever I do, even at work behind my cash register, to have a good time and build relationships with people, but to feel good, to feel myself, and to show my enthusiasm and interest in the world around me. I tend to be curious and enthusiastic, even admiring and fascinated by the world around me, like a child. I already feel this way alone, and in my romantic relationships, this is a first for me—to be fascinated by the world around me, to be amazed, to be amazed alone but also together. I think I've touched on one of the most important and nourishing things for me by accessing this.

Speaker 1 [00:21:52] Yes, quality time for you is being yourself with someone else.

Speaker 2 [00:21:57] Yes, and doing an activity that excites me. There are many activities I enjoy. It can be grocery shopping, working behind the cash register, chatting with customers, going to the gym, hiking—so many possibilities. It doesn't have to be something extraordinary like skydiving. It can be everyday things.

Speaker 1 [00:22:29] Everyday things.

Speaker 2 [00:22:30] Yes. Finding happiness in everyday things. And when I can share that happiness with someone else, it's... When we can share it together, it's... It's bliss.

Speaker 1 [00:22:40] It's bliss. I'd like to go back a bit. Earlier, we talked about friendships. I'd like to know if you had to compare the quality of your current relationship with the couple relationships of your friends.

Speaker 2 [00:22:57] It's very difficult to compare because among my closest friends, I'm one of the few in an exclusive relationship with someone. I don't necessarily want to see others, nor am I in polyamory or an open relationship. I'm one of the rare dinosaurs still in an exclusive romantic relationship. Around me, most friends are either single by choice or haven't found someone, or they're in multiple relationships—troupeles, polyamory, or open relationships. This gives me an insight into what's possible and how everyone finds their place in relationships. I see my friends feel good about it, and I have a little sister or brother, depending on the day, who was also searching for romantic relationships but rather multiple relationships. I see how it works for them, and I don't want that because it doesn't suit me. I'm happy for my friends because they feel good about it. Some friends are still searching, and we talk about it. For friends in relationships as long as or shorter than mine, things often go wrong. I see many small communication issues in their couples that make me and [partner] wonder. They often say things like, "You didn't tell me that," "You never tell me anything," "Why do you do it this way?" Always almost accusing the other. Always, "You didn't tell me that," "You're really incompetent,"

sometimes jokingly but still. We don't find it funny. We find it weird to talk like that. We discuss it later.

Speaker 1 [00:25:47] And why do they talk like that?

Speaker 2 [00:25:49] I don't know if it's a communication style or something learned from childhood. It's something learned while growing up. I realized in my communication a few years ago, it was about the "you" in phrases like "you annoy me," "why do you do that?" "you never make an effort." That's something I tried to avoid in my relationships because it's not something I'd like to hear and because, as the saying goes, the "you" kills. "You" kills relationships and accuses the other. When something's wrong, I'd rather talk about my feelings than what the other did wrong. Instead of saying, "you annoy me," I'd say, "I don't feel comfortable with this." I avoid using "you" as much as possible.

Speaker 1 [00:27:13] I understand what you're saying. It's a way to avoid accusations.

Speaker 2 [00:27:19] Yes. To express feelings without accusing the other. It doesn't change the situation and only makes the other question everything, get defensive, or angry. The message won't get through.

Speaker 1 [00:27:40] And that's something you notice in your friends' relationships compared to yours.

Speaker 2 [00:27:48] Yes, I tend to notice that.

Speaker 1 [00:27:52] I'd like you to talk about what a high-quality relationship means to you.

Speaker 2 [00:27:59] Wait. I need a drink because I talk a lot.

Speaker 1 [00:28:01] Please, go ahead.

Speaker 2 [00:28:02] And I'm thirsty. A high-quality relationship. Well. (laughs) Big question again. It's a relationship where there's no communication flaw, but we learn from mistakes and can question ourselves without completely tearing ourselves down, saying, "I'm useless," but recognizing an issue and evolving from it. It's about learning to communicate with the other. It's not innate; there's always a communication flaw in every relationship, even in mine. There's always something that doesn't get across, but we talk about it and move forward alone and together. A high-quality relationship for me, you've guessed, involves spending quality time with the person. Not necessarily extraordinary things, but being fully present with each other. It involves affection without having to ask for it. It's not a long-distance relationship, which I don't want and wouldn't recommend because such relationships magnify presence and absence equally. A high-quality relationship also allows for time alone or with friends, where we're not always with the other but can do other things. I'm staying at my mom's this summer, knowing my boyfriend can't join me. I'll miss him a lot for [1-5] months, but I'll be thrilled to see him again, knowing we're together the rest of the year. It's a relationship with closeness, where even if we're not in each other's universe initially, we can understand and be open to each other's

worlds, maybe advise each other. A relationship where we want to build something together. Romantic relationships vary with each individual, but for me, a couple's relationship is about evolving and building something together, not necessarily marriage, kids, or buying a house—these are personal choices—but having projects together, like traveling or starting a business. There are many possibilities.

Speaker 1 [00:31:31] If I understand correctly, you want both time together, looking in the same direction, and also giving each other space.

Speaker 2 [00:31:40] Yes, that's very important to me. A relationship can end, but we can still maintain some form of relationship. We might become friends or stay in touch. My parents are still in contact despite not being together. Our family [Social Media] group has never been more active since they separated. But how do I put it? I lost my train of thought.

Speaker 1 [00:32:24] Take your time.

Speaker 2 [00:32:27] If a couple's relationship ends, we need to keep building our lives. We can't base our entire lives on the couple because if the relationship ends, what's left? We spent months or years over-investing in the couple, and if the other person leaves, what do we have? We need to rebuild our lives alone. For me, it's crucial to keep nurturing individual interests and our own lives. I like the stool metaphor because I do many things and have various interests. The more legs a stool has, the more stable it is. If a stool has three legs and loses one, it falls. If it has six or seven legs and loses one, it's still stable. The same goes for us.

Speaker 1 [00:34:07] So you aim to have as many legs as possible.

Speaker 2 [00:34:11] Maybe not the most legs, but stable ones contributing to my balance. If I lose one, it won't drastically change my life's balance. I'll need to adjust, but I'll have other things to rely on for happiness.

Speaker 1 [00:34:38] You've talked about many aspects of a high-quality relationship. You mentioned communication. I'd like you to talk about how we know we're in a communicative relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:35:05] I think it's mainly about feeling. We all have a small intuition that tells us when things are going well or when something's wrong. When the other person is not well, it shows. The difficulty with communication in a couple is that sometimes, something can happen, and relationships can end due to a lack of communication or communication issues. It's common when you look closely. I don't have statistics; it's more your field than mine, but empirically, it's easily observed. It's insidious because we don't see it at first. It's like anorexia, which starts with a small diet, removing a few foods, then more until you eat nothing. Communication is similar. It starts with a small benign phrase that seems insignificant, like a joke, but it adds up. If we accept one, then another, it builds up and becomes a real issue. We might not realize it initially, but over time, it can escalate to violence or things we'd never accept. Why? Because it started small and grew. That's why I emphasize communication a lot. I don't know if [partner] will mention it in his interview, but it's something we discuss regarding

communication in couples. It's very important to him too. We don't have serious discussions about it often, but we do have them.

Speaker 1 [00:38:14] I understand what you're saying. It's not just about communication, but good communication.

Speaker 2 [00:38:20] Both are important. Good communication, but we can't always be perfect. We're human and sometimes say things out of anger that we regret. The key is to question ourselves and apologize if we say something hurtful. Apologize, say we didn't mean it.

Speaker 1 [00:39:04] When you talk about communication, you focus on over-communication, saying too much, not regretting what's unsaid.

Speaker 2 [00:39:14] True, there are things we don't say or do. Communication isn't just words; it's actions. We have needs, and knowing and discussing them is crucial. In many relationships, and I've experienced it too, there are needs we may feel are fundamental but don't express out of fear of rejection, the other's reaction, or feeling illegitimate.

Speaker 1 [00:40:21] Things we may not feel legitimate to say.

Speaker 2 [00:40:25] Yes. And I know that's something that happens to me too, in my current relationship. It's happened several times. But it's not something that happens every day, thankfully. There are times when there are important topics I need to discuss with [partner]. It's mainly about finding the right moment to talk to him. It's complicated because he has a job; he works nights, so he comes home in the morning tired. That's when I'm getting up. We often have different schedules, and both have our heads down with our studies—mine and my job, and his various activities. Finding a time when we're both available and not too tired to talk is tough. Sometimes I need to talk to him about something, but because I want to choose the right moment, I don't bring it up. I can wait a week or two before talking about it because it doesn't feel like the right time.

Speaker 1 [00:41:45] It's also about finding the right time to communicate.

Speaker 2 [00:41:48] Yes, and it's not always easy to find the right time. Even when the other person seems available, we're not in their head, and we can't know 100% if it's the right moment or not. It's up to the other person to let us know if they're ready to talk or not. Usually, I ask [partner] if he's available, if he can talk because I need to discuss something. If he says yes, we talk. If he says no, I wait or ask when would be a good time. Sometimes he can't answer due to his unpredictable schedule, both work and mentally. But the cool thing is he won't make me wait weeks to discuss something.

Speaker 1 [00:42:50] We're talking about communication, especially "miscommunication"—communication that isn't right, that can hurt, like the accusatory "you," the little digs, and choosing the wrong moments. What benefits does communication have for you?

Speaker 2 [00:43:14] There are many. First, we get to know each other better, which is important. We learn where the relationship stands because it's an entity on its own, and we're both invested in it as individuals. We understand the relationship's evolution, which we need to discuss together. We learn about ourselves and convey to the other person where we are in our lives. (laughs) How can I put it? Could you repeat the question so I can elaborate?

Speaker 1 [00:44:21] It's not really a question. I was wondering, since you talk a lot about communication and its issues when it's not right, when it's mistimed, when it hurts, I'd like to hear from you what communication can bring, rather than what it can take away.

Speaker 2 [00:44:40] So, as I was saying, it helps to know the other person better, understand where the relationship is, understand ourselves, enrich each other by sharing and learning from each other. It can even help us communicate things to ourselves. For example, discussing something that the other person isn't directly involved in—like my artistic process—I might not get answers from them, but talking about it helps me understand what I'm saying. I find answers more easily than if I wrote it down or just thought about it alone. I could think about it for hours and get nowhere, but talking to the other person, even if they don't respond, can help me figure it out.

Speaker 1 [00:45:55] Like a mirror.

Speaker 2 [00:45:56] Yes. Sometimes, without even responding, the other person helps us find our own answers. Then we thank them, and they say, "I didn't do anything." But they were there, and that's what's important.

Speaker 1 [00:46:18] So, communicating with the other person is also sometimes communicating with yourself.

Speaker 2 [00:46:22] Yes. Yes, that's part of it, I think.

Speaker 1 [00:46:32] A way to formalize, perhaps out loud, things and internal states that, when put into words, allow us to see them clearly.

Speaker 2 [00:46:44] Yes, exactly. It's not like talking to a therapist because it's not guided and you don't pay 60 euros for the session. But it forces us to verbalize internal states that we wouldn't necessarily express alone. Having someone in front of us helps us work through these states and find solutions. I observe this in myself and in others. Whether with [partner] or others, even with my parents, I see how talking about our internal states helps us progress.

Speaker 1 [00:47:48] It helps a lot.

Speaker 2 [00:47:49] Yes.

Speaker 1 [00:47:53] You said it helps a lot. Does it build the relationship? Does it increase happiness?

Speaker 2 [00:48:03] It enhances the relationship itself. Maybe, but it mainly helps us evolve individually, becoming a better version of ourselves and potentially happier, more authentic. If we feel more ourselves, the relationship can only get better.

Speaker 1 [00:48:34] The relationship can only get better if we feel more ourselves.

Speaker 2 [00:48:38] Yes. I'm convinced of that.

Speaker 1 [00:48:42] You're convinced?

Speaker 2 [00:48:43] Yes. My experiences, including my current one with [partner], show me that. When we don't feel well—we can be in a suitable relationship and still feel unwell—it depends on individual circumstances. But in my case, I noticed that in relationships where I felt really unwell, like during adolescence, they were often more turbulent. I was more emotional and feared abandonment. That fear is still there, but much less. In relationships where I wasn't well with myself, I was more needy, over-invested, almost to the point of emotional dependency. I constantly needed affection and felt unworthy of love if I didn't get it.

Speaker 2 [00:50:29] That's why I focus on self-care alongside my relationships. When younger, I didn't realize that nurturing myself also nurtures the relationship. A relationship based solely on affection and kind words can exhaust itself over time if we don't bring anything from outside. If we're always together, we run out of things to say.

Speaker 1 [00:51:18] So, it's essential to bring things from outside.

Speaker 2 [00:51:19] Yes. It's like a garden with diverse flowers; if it only has one variety, it becomes monotonous. We need variety to keep it interesting.

Speaker 1 [00:51:41] Go ahead, finish your metaphor.

Speaker 2 [00:51:43] No, I'm done with my metaphor.

Speaker 1 [00:51:50] I understand what you're saying.

Speaker 2 [00:51:54] Cool. (laughs)

Speaker 1 [00:51:55] You've talked about what a high-quality relationship means to you. Now, I'd like you to describe what a low-quality relationship is.

Speaker 2 [00:52:05] Good question. There are millions of possibilities, as many as there are individuals and relationships. I've listened to many stories about people in relationships with narcissistic abusers, although I dislike that term as it's often misused. But relationships with people who have narcissistic personality disorder can drain your energy and consume you. In such relationships, you're given what you want on a silver platter, but after a few months, you hear a phrase like "you're really incompetent," "you don't know how to do this," "let me do it," which makes you feel bad. Such phrases are so unexpected that you can't believe it. You're so

surprised that you don't realize what was said. This leads to more hurtful comments and gradually accepting them, allowing your integrity to be undermined—your way of existing, your appearance, your beliefs. You're loved conditionally: "I love you, but only if you dress differently, or see your friends less." I've had relationships like that, even if they weren't extreme. For instance, at [11-15], I dated a boy my age who, within [1-5] and a half months, contacted all the girls in my class to flirt, found a new girlfriend across the country, copied love messages he sent me to send to others, and tried to assault me. I talk about it lightly because I've worked through it, but it was devastating. He was the first person I decided I never wanted in my life again. I preferred bad company over being alone.

Speaker 1 [00:57:44] It relates to the idea of losing oneself in a relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:57:53] Yes, completely. I didn't know myself, didn't love myself, and had no self-esteem. I only existed through relationships because I had few friends. I sought love where I could, in romantic relationships.

Speaker 1 [00:58:26] That's why it's crucial for you now to nourish yourself first, to then nourish the relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:58:33] Yes, especially after such experiences. It's vital.

Speaker 1 [00:58:43] So, for you, a low-quality relationship is one where you're not yourself, make concessions you wouldn't usually make, almost under the potential happiness the relationship might bring or the possibility of being loved.

Speaker 2 [00:59:03] Exactly.

Speaker 1 [00:59:08] I'd like you to talk about other things, if any, that are most important to you in a relationship.

Speaker 2 [00:59:21] (laughs) I'm thinking about it. Nothing comes to mind immediately. (long pause) One thing very important to me now, which I've experienced with [partner] and never considered before, is this: [partner] once asked me to introduce him to my stuffed animals. I have many, and they are a part of me. They bring me comfort. He also loves stuffed animals. When he asked, I realized he was the right person. You never know for sure, but at that moment, I knew he was the right one.

Speaker 1 [01:00:55] What touched you about his request to see your stuffed animals?

Speaker 2 [01:01:05] (laughs) It's hard to define, but... I have a very childlike side, which I value greatly. It's essential to keep one's childlike heart, a value we share. For us, stuffed animals are significant. We care for them, and toys too. Some people might see them as trivial, but for us, they're crucial.

Speaker 1 [01:02:08] You felt accepted.

Speaker 2 [01:02:11] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:02:12] And understood.

Speaker 2 [01:02:14] Completely.

Speaker 1 [01:02:16] That's why it was so important to you. As you said, it might seem trivial to others, but he understood its value to you, leading to a feeling of acceptance and trust.

Speaker 2 [01:02:34] Yes, completely. I've always been in my own bubble. I might be slightly autistic, although I don't like labeling it. It runs in the family. I see traits in myself and him that suggest we're similar in that way. Our bubbles are so close that we connect deeply.

Speaker 1 [01:03:42] You mentioned this topic earlier, and I'd like you to talk more about what love means to you, based on your experiences.

Speaker 2 [01:04:01] Wow! (laughs) It's a broad term. Love, I think, is primarily about affinity with the other person or people. There are many ways to love. It involves affinity, acceptance, recognizing the other as an individual, and wanting to discover them. Depending on the type of love, there might be physical attraction, although that's secondary. We love our friends, family, romantic partners, even colleagues. There are many ways to love, and I love many people for different reasons, sometimes for no reason, just because they are themselves. Admiration is a part of it too. I can't define love precisely. The heart has its reasons that reason ignores, right? (laughs) Physical attraction matters, but I also love people I'm not physically attracted to or who aren't considered beautiful by societal standards. They could be disabled, have a missing finger, be in poor health, or have asymmetrical faces. It's not about appearance. It's a deeper connection, more profound, like the layers of the earth, going from the crust to the mantle and the core.

Speaker 1 [01:07:05] More profound.

Speaker 2 [01:07:06] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:07:08] This depth, for you, means it's more rooted.

Speaker 2 [01:07:12] I don't know if that's the right term, but it's part of it. It's something deeper, not just superficial.

Speaker 1 [01:07:30] How important is this depth in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2 [01:07:35] For me, it's crucial. I love people in general and tend to give love freely without expecting anything in return. It nourishes me to give. In a relationship, loving is vital. Not loving means dislike or indifference, and indifference in a relationship brings no value to anyone. It means something is missing, something that doesn't match.

Speaker 1 [01:09:38] Things that don't match in indifference.

Speaker 2 [01:09:40] Yes, like a painting in a museum. Some paintings move us, others don't. Why stay in front of a painting that does nothing for us? It's taking up space for someone who might appreciate it.

Speaker 1 [01:10:46] It's a matter of suitability for you.

Speaker 2 [01:10:49] I think so. Relationships can change over time. What doesn't work now might work later. But generally, you feel when it doesn't work.

Speaker 1 [01:11:10] You feel it.

Speaker 2 [01:11:11] But life can surprise you sometimes.

Speaker 1 [01:11:18] You mentioned positive interactions with your partner earlier. Can you describe one of your recent positive interactions?

Speaker 2 [01:11:36] One of our recent positive interactions was yesterday. He sent me a reel, a video on [Social Media]. Sometimes we share funny cat videos. This one made us laugh, and we commented on it, recalling other videos, discussing them. That's it. (laughs)

Speaker 1 [01:12:13] On the contrary, can you describe one of your recent negative interactions with him?

Speaker 2 [01:12:22] Good question. I have one in mind, but it's hardly negative. It was two days ago. He noticed some spoons were missing from our cutlery set. I took one because I traveled, so I had cutlery with me. But we're missing three spoons. He mentioned it because he doesn't want mismatched cutlery if we buy new ones. I thought, well, cutlery is just cutlery. But he values living in a very clean, minimalist space. I do too, but I'm less particular about mismatched cutlery or small details. He cares more because he didn't have that growing up. It's not that he's picky, but it matters to him. I benefit from a neat home, so I invest in it too. It makes me happy too. Is this really a negative interaction? (laughs) It's the most negative thing we've had in months.

Speaker 1 [01:14:30] Why did you consider it a negative interaction?

Speaker 2 [01:14:36] Because it's a small disagreement or minor issue in daily life. We lost three spoons. It bothers him, so we talk about it. Sometimes I'm not careful, or maybe he wasn't careful either. So we discuss it.

Speaker 1 [01:15:03] Can you think of another negative interaction, perhaps more distant?

Speaker 2 [01:15:11] I'll try. (long pause) A negative interaction... I remember one about him leaving his [group]. I wanted to know his feelings and later heard the group's side. Both sides had issues, and communication was tough. I offered to mediate because they were friends, and it's good to help. But I struggled to find the right time to talk to him. I wasn't comfortable since it didn't concern me directly. I worried he might react badly. Eventually, I told him, "I need to talk to

you about something important, but it's hard to find the right moment." I almost cried while saying it, "I need to talk, but it's tough because we're both busy." Finally, I talked to him. The challenge was conveying others' feelings, which weren't mine. He was defensive at times, and I had to remind him, "Don't be mad at me; I'm just relaying what they said."

Speaker 1 [01:18:03] Was that a negative interaction for you?

Speaker 2 [01:18:06] Yes, because I was uncomfortable.

Speaker 1 [01:18:13] Can you talk about the challenges in your relationship?

Speaker 2 [01:18:20] So, the challenges to overcome. I think they will be more financial. (laughs) Since we both have multiple activities, it will be about finding a financial balance by saving. For now, things are going well, even though my income is what it is, student income. He has his salary, but he also has a budding video business and has made some money from music, which he won't have anymore since he's leaving his band. So, the difficulty will be—not immediately but in the next five or ten years—finding a balance, both individually and together. That's the biggest challenge, which is quite significant.

Speaker 1 [01:19:32] And the challenges you have already overcome?

Speaker 2 [01:19:35] Hmm... Oh yes, there's a second one. Thanks for bringing that up. Another difficulty is that his father lived with him before, and it's very complicated for him to find a new apartment. He can't manage on his own. One thing that scares me, knowing him, is that financially things might not go well for his father, or he might not manage his money well. If his father were to pass away—since we all die eventually—if that happens, [partner] might have to deal with his debts. That's something that scares me. At some point, we'll have to do something, or at least [partner] will need to take action, though I think it's important we do it together. We should consult a lawyer or someone to understand what might happen and if necessary, consider guardianship for his father. I don't know his financial situation, but it doesn't seem like he can buy a house or even an apartment. Renting, yes, but buying, no. He had savings, but they're gone, which says something. One major difficulty we overcame together was moving out of his old apartment. He lived there for [16-20] years, and so did his father. The challenge was that his father lived there, but the lease was in [partner]'s name. His father didn't want to leave. The rent was high for a dilapidated place. The landlord was quite shady, constantly raising the rent. We're glad to be out of that situation. Helping with the move and cleaning was tough, but I insisted on helping even though he initially didn't want me to. It was exhausting, but we got through it, and it was nice to share a burger in the empty apartment afterward. That was always nice.

Speaker 1 [01:23:32] We talked a bit about this, but sometimes, in a relationship, not everything is rosy. I'd like you to talk about the conflicts and disputes you have with your partner.

Speaker 2 [01:23:42] We rarely have disputes. We have disagreements, but actual disputes are very rare. It's happened once or twice that [partner] got angry because of something I did

that annoyed him, and he started yelling. I hate conflicts. I don't mind talking, but I hate conflicts. When someone yells at me, I tend to lower my head and wait for it to pass. Knowing [partner], it ends quickly. After he yells, we talk about it. But this has happened only once or twice, at most. We've never had a full-blown argument where we both got involved in yelling.

Speaker 1 [01:25:00] So, you'd say these conflicts... they have a certain frequency... these small disagreements.

Speaker 2 [01:25:06] Yes, there are small disagreements, but never a major conflict.

Speaker 1 [01:25:15] These small disagreements, how often do they occur, say, over a fortnight or a month?

Speaker 2 [01:25:23] They're minor things, like one of us stressing out. It's usually related to a strong emotion or feeling that the other is doing too much.

Speaker 1 [01:25:43] How do you resolve these conflicts or disputes, or small disagreements?

Speaker 2 [01:25:52] We handle it differently. I tend to distance myself and then say, "I don't accept this. I understand you're angry, but how you acted didn't feel good, made me uncomfortable." I don't talk about it immediately; I wait a bit. I let him calm down, usually quickly, then I talk to him. Sometimes his behavior makes me feel unrecognized, but I tell him. When I'm stressed, I become hyperactive, running around, tidying up, ignoring him. He raises his voice to snap me out of it, and then it gets better. Then we hug.

Speaker 1 [01:27:56] Alright. You said, "sometimes something goes wrong, but I talk to him." Again, communication for conflict resolution.

Speaker 2 [01:28:07] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:28:09] For conflict resolution.

Speaker 2 [01:28:11] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:28:12] Yes?

Speaker 2 [01:28:14] Sometimes it takes a while before I talk to him about it. If I don't feel ready to talk, I wait. It never makes things worse; it helps me gain perspective.

Speaker 1 [01:28:50] Gaining perspective?

Speaker 2 [01:28:52] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:28:55] Something important for you in these conflicts or disputes you might have.

Speaker 2 [01:29:02] It's very important to me. Reacting immediately is rarely a good reaction.

Speaker 1 [01:29:18] I'd like to know, I'd like you to talk about the ways you both maintain your relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:29:27] There are many ways (laughs). As I mentioned, we spend quality time together in various ways. It could be grocery shopping, watching streams, eating together while watching something on YouTube or streams, sleeping together—even though it's not every night because he works nights, and that counts. We surprise each other with little things. For his 30th birthday, I took him to the beach for the weekend. We give each other gifts, not to show love, but because they're useful. We make lists, and the other picks something from it. He's into video and music gear, so I choose what he needs most. Supporting each other's passions is crucial. I watch his edits, give feedback, and encourage him. He takes photos for me at school since he has a great camera. We share our interests, go for runs together (though rarely because I outpace him), and cuddle. There are endless possibilities, even just sitting and petting the cats.

Speaker 1 [01:32:06] There's this notion of spending quality time together.

Speaker 2 [01:32:08] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:32:11] I'd like to know what could make you leave your partner.

Speaker 2 [01:32:23] Honestly, nothing. Nothing, not even my career. I wouldn't leave him for anything.

Speaker 1 [01:32:39] Would you say this relationship is good for you?

Speaker 2 [01:32:44] Yes. It brings me so much; I feel truly nourished by it and enriched in every way—professionally, personally, I feel more legitimate to be myself.

Speaker 1 [01:33:17] You said you feel nourished.

Speaker 2 [01:33:19] Yes, it's a relationship that nourishes me. Not just with good food (laughs).

Speaker 1 [01:33:32] Do you think you're the same person as before your relationship, or has it changed you?

Speaker 2 [01:33:42] It hasn't changed me, but it has helped me evolve, undoubtedly. Even physically; I've lost about ten kilos since we met. I struggled with my weight and tried everything to lose it, but he suggested counting calories, something my mom was against. He gave me an app he used, and I started counting. I lost weight and took up weightlifting. He encourages me, and he's proud. He's proud to see me enjoy these activities. He loved me before and loves me now. He gave me this tool.

Speaker 1 [01:35:30] So you haven't changed, but you've evolved.

Speaker 2 [01:35:33] Yes, I've evolved for the better.

Speaker 1 [01:35:37] For the better.

Speaker 2 [01:35:39] I feel like a "better version of myself."

Speaker 1 [01:35:46] And regarding your partner, do you think he has changed during the relationship?

Speaker 2 [01:35:54] No, he hasn't changed, but like me, he's more himself. He exercises less, but that's because he's focused on his new business. I believe our relationship has given him confidence, though I wouldn't boast about it since I'm not in his head. He seems happier and more fulfilled. He left his apartment of [16-20] years, which was a big change, but it was a positive evolution.

Speaker 1 [01:37:15] An evolution in the same way.

Speaker 2 [01:37:16] Yes. Although the ten kilos I lost, he gained (laughs). He enjoys good food and doesn't count calories. He used to play three hours of basketball a day, but now he doesn't have the time. He wants to get back into it, and I encourage him. He'll resume when he's ready, and it'll be good for him.

Speaker 1 [01:37:58] You mentioned earlier that you feel secure in the relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:38:04] Absolutely. I don't even question if he'll leave me, unlike in past relationships. We're together, and that's it. We both maintain our individuality in the relationship, so there's no reason to leave if we're happy and still have our own little worlds.

Speaker 1 [01:38:59] You talked about opening up to your partner about your experiences, thoughts, and identity without fear of judgment...

Speaker 2 [01:39:11] Yes, and I do that daily.

Speaker 1 [01:39:15] And receiving comfort or attention in times of danger, distress, or difficulty.

Speaker 2 [01:39:24] Yes, absolutely. There have been times when I wasn't doing well. We all have moments like that, questioning ourselves, our work, everything. Last summer, my parents divorced, and I lost my cat, which was extremely painful and still is. He's there to listen, support me, and hold me. He's my shoulder to cry on. I was surprised because I wouldn't have been able to handle these things [1-5] years ago. The stability I had with my family was gone, but I didn't fall apart because I had him to hold on to.

Speaker 1 [01:40:45] There's a notion of a supportive, helpful relationship.

Speaker 2 [01:40:51] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:40:53] You also mentioned earlier the complicity you share with your partner, akin to friendship.

Speaker 2 [01:41:02] Yes. We weren't friends before dating; there was immediate attraction when we started talking and meeting outside of work. I felt an inexplicable attraction to him that's still there. Our complicity feels like friendship, maybe even more. The only person I'm as close to is my mom.

Speaker 1 [01:41:47] I'd like to briefly touch on another aspect of a couple's relationship: sexuality. It can be more or less important. What does it mean to you?

Speaker 2 [01:41:59] Sexuality is important, but not paramount. It's linked with tenderness and complicity. We can make little allusions or share moments without necessarily having sex. It wasn't easy for me, especially after a rape attempt. My libido isn't very high, which caused issues in past relationships. I felt abnormal. Now, I know there are men with lower libido like mine, who don't prioritize it in a relationship. It's a relief. I used to question myself over things I can't change. I never thought it possible to have a relaxed and peaceful relationship regarding sex. I'm still not entirely comfortable with it, though.

Speaker 1 [01:44:16] Not entirely comfortable with it.

Speaker 2 [01:44:20] Sexuality? No, not very comfortable talking about it publicly.

Speaker 1 [01:44:29] Talking about it publicly, you mean.

Speaker 2 [01:44:31] Yes, talking about it publicly. Even within the relationship, some things are not easy. But it's not related to him; it's about me. It might be due to certain neuroses I have, which I might need to work on in therapy. But I've already seen improvement.

Speaker 1 [01:45:01] You've seen improvement.

Speaker 2 [01:45:03] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:45:06] Again, there's this notion of acceptance that's important to you.

Speaker 2 [01:45:14] Always. Always.

Speaker 1 [01:45:17] Currently, roughly, what's the frequency of your sexual relations? You mentioned libido might...

Speaker 2 [01:45:26] (laughs) It's very irregular. Sometimes, there are no relations for two or three months, then several in a week. If I had to give a frequency, I'd say maybe once a month.

Speaker 1 [01:45:57] Would you say you're satisfied with your sex life?

Speaker 2 [01:46:00] Yes, totally. Completely.

Speaker 1 [01:46:07] I'll share my screen now. There will be a scale. I'll ask you to answer two items. Can you see it correctly?

Speaker 2 [01:46:21] Yes.

Speaker 1 [01:46:23] So, in general, my partner really listens to me. It ranges from 1 to 9, with one being "not at all true" and nine being "completely true." Where would you place yourself?

Speaker 2 [01:46:33] Can I give half scores?

Speaker 1 [01:46:37] Yes, you can.

Speaker 2 [01:46:39] I'd say eight and a half.

Speaker 1 [01:46:41] Why eight and a half?

Speaker 2 [01:46:43] Sometimes I talk to him when I'm in my bubble, not checking if he's available. So I start talking and realize he's not ignoring me but is busy.

Speaker 1 [01:47:05] If you had to choose between eight and nine?

Speaker 2 [01:47:08] Then eight. It's not that he doesn't listen, but I don't always choose the right moment.

Speaker 1 [01:47:17] Why not seven?

Speaker 2 [01:47:20] Because it doesn't happen very often.

Speaker 1 [01:47:28] My partner is generally attentive to my needs. On the same scale, one being "not at all true," three "somewhat true," five "moderately true," seven "very true," and nine "completely true."

Speaker 2 [01:47:36] Nine.

Speaker 1 [01:47:37] Nine? Why nine?

Speaker 2 [01:47:40] Because he's always attentive to my needs. I don't always need to express them; sometimes, he meets them without me even articulating them.

Speaker 1 [01:48:01] Why not eight?

Speaker 2 [01:48:03] Because I've never felt any need unmet.

Speaker 1 [01:48:16] "How satisfied are you with your relationship?" It ranges from "completely dissatisfied," "very dissatisfied," "somewhat dissatisfied," "uncertain/neutral," "somewhat satisfied," "very satisfied," and "completely satisfied."

Speaker 2 [01:48:27] Completely satisfied.

Speaker 1 [01:48:31] You answered verbally. If I translated this scale to a numerical form, zero being "not at all satisfied" and ten "completely satisfied," where would you place yourself?

Speaker 2 [01:48:41] Ten.

Speaker 1 [01:48:44] Why ten?

Speaker 2 [01:48:47] Maybe for everything I said before. I'm satisfied on all fronts. There's nothing I'd change. When you love someone to the point where even their sweat smells good, it's a sign. (laughs)

Speaker 1 [01:49:16] We're nearing the end of the interview.

Speaker 2 [01:49:19] Okay.

Speaker 1 [01:49:22] Is there anything you'd like to add, clarify, or correct?

Speaker 2 [01:49:28] I think we've covered everything.

Speaker 1 [01:49:32] Take your time to think. You said "pretty much," so there might be other things that come to mind or things you thought about but didn't mention at the time.

Speaker 2 [01:49:40] No, I've said everything that came to mind.

Speaker 1 [01:49:46] In that case, I'll stop the recording.

Speaker 2 [01:49:48] Yes.